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The First Marriage

In AD 1488, Aisha Sulṭān Begum[1] was engaged to Babur in Samarkand. Babur was just six years old then. She was the daughter of his paternal uncle Sulṭān Ahmad Mīrzā and his mother's sister, Qutaq Begum. Sulṭān Ahmad Mīrzā arrived in Andijān with his daughter Aisha sometime in the first quarter of AD 1500. She was married to Babur in the month of Shaban.

Babur has given an account (in the *Baburnama*) of how he was a shy person. And it is even more interesting is that he has blamed the shyness on the fact that it it was his *first* marriage. His assertion of 'first marriage' makes one believe that he was forseeing more marriages, which was an obvious trait of the society he belonged to.

Because of his shyness and modesty (as Babur has claimed in the *Baburnama*), he visited her only once every two or three weeks. But it was not very late when he stopped with those bimonthly visits too. Babur has written in the *Baburnama* that he had begun to lose inclination and attraction for Aisha Sulṭān Begum. And then Babur's mother Khānum intervened as she was not at all happy with her son's actions. Upon his mother's insistence, Babur resumed his visits to Aisha but only once every seven weeks or so. Babur's writings make us believe that something was wrong in his marriage with Aisha. What was it?

Perhaps, Babur was bisexual and was more inclined towards men than women, at least in that period. Babur does mention that in those leisurely days, he had discovered a strange inclination in himself. He writes:[*]

> I maddened and afflicted myself for a boy in the camp bazar, his very name, Baburi, fitting in. Up till then, I had had no inclination for anyone, indeed of love and desire, either by hear-say or experience, I had not heard, I had not talked.